knew she was her whole world. And in return, Léa was grateful because for the few moments it took to care for her, she forgot about Josef, Rose and André.

After Katya fell asleep, Léa—wrapped her in the sling on her back—picked up the bag and started walking. She stopped at the stream and collected water to wash the blood away. Then she dried Katya and herself with one of the towels in her bag. She had a compass and used it to find north, then she started walking, determined to reach the Elbe.

Soon, she was out of the forest. She stayed away from roads, preferring fields and walking paths. Whenever she saw people drifting in bands, she slunk back, keeping her distance. Dusk dangled in the sky—pale blue and white clouds, a golden light floating in between. She had never seen such a beautiful sky as the one that appeared before darkness fell.

Farmhouse up ahead. Needing milk, she knocked on the door. A man came out with a Karabiner aimed at her. He shouted that she should go away but his wife, seeing the baby on Léa's back, took the gun out of her husband's hand. She motioned for Léa to come forward.

"We have cows. I will give you milk. But don't stay here. Keep moving."

"How far to the Elbe?" Léa asked.

"Five kilometers." The woman gave her a piece of bread. "You're close."

"Thank you."

She took the milk and bread and continued on her way. The one question that coursed through her like the blood pumping up to her heart: would she ever see her sister again?

At nightfall, she arrived in Prina. The town was eerily quiet. A bridge up ahead, the Elbe flowed under it. She would cross that bridge, and on the other side, she'd be free. A jeep rolled alongside her. Two soldiers with American flags on their sleeves sat inside. They stopped. "There's a curfew. No one is allowed out after dark."

She told them her story. Luckily, they understood a few German words. The moment she uttered *Zwangsarbeiter*, forced worker, they nodded and helped her and Katya climb into the back of the jeep. Finally, Léa crossed over the bridge to the Allied side.